

THREE-MILK VANILLA TRES LECHES

Eggless vanilla sponge • classic three-milk soak • whipped cream • fresh fruit

Recipe concept: A soft, fine-crumb eggless vanilla sponge that absorbs a classic three-milk mixture while holding its shape in an elegant ceramic dessert bowl.

Yield: One 23 × 33 cm sponge sheet, approximately 12 portions. Assembly: 6–8 dessert bowls depending on size. Active time: 35–45 minutes. Baking: 22–28 minutes. Chilling: at least 4 hours, preferably overnight.

1. Equipment

• 23 × 33 cm (9 × 13 inch) metal baking pan

• Parchment paper and a little neutral oil for greasing

• Two large mixing bowls, sieve, whisk and silicone spatula

• Offset spatula, wire rack and serrated knife

• Small bowl for mixing the three milks

• Shallow ivory ceramic dessert bowls for serving

• Whisk or electric hand mixer for whipped cream

• Piping bag and nozzle (optional; a spoon works too)

2. Eggless Vanilla Sponge Sheet

Ingredients

Ingredient	Quantity
Plain flour (maida)	240 g
Cornflour (cornstarch)	30 g
Baking powder	8 g
Baking soda	2 g
Fine salt	3 g
Caster sugar	200 g
Full-fat milk	240 g

Ingredient	Quantity
Plain, unsweetened yogurt	120 g
Neutral oil	80 g
Vanilla extract	10 g
White vinegar (5% acidity)	5 g

Method — follow in order

1. Prepare: Heat a conventional oven to **170°C** (or **160°C fan**). Place the rack in the middle. Line the base and sides of the 23 × 33 cm pan with parchment and lightly grease.

2. Sift: Sift flour, cornflour, baking powder, baking soda and salt together. Whisk for about 30 seconds to distribute the raising agents evenly.

3. Mix wet ingredients: Warm milk to approximately **30–35°C**—lukewarm, not hot. Whisk in sugar until dispersed. Whisk in yogurt, oil and vanilla until uniform. Add vinegar last, just before combining.

4. Combine gently: Pour wet ingredients into dry. Whisk slowly only until no dry flour pockets remain. Scrape the bowl once with a spatula. A few tiny lumps are fine; stop before the batter becomes elastic or gluey.

5. Fill and level: Pour into the prepared pan. Spread evenly into the corners with an offset spatula and tap the pan gently once to release large air pockets.

6. Bake: Bake for approximately **22–28 minutes**, checking from 22 minutes. Avoid opening the oven during the first 18 minutes. The centre should spring back gently; a skewer should show no wet batter, though a few moist crumbs are fine.

7. Cool fully: Cool in the pan for 10–15 minutes, lift out using the parchment and transfer to a wire rack. Let cool completely, then cover and chill 30–45 minutes for cleaner cutting.

3. Classic Three-Milk Soak

Use whole milk, evaporated milk and sweetened condensed milk. Condensed milk is sweetened and thick; evaporated milk is unsweetened concentrated milk. They are not interchangeable.

Ingredient	Starting quantity
Full-fat milk	180 g
Evaporated milk (unsweetened)	180 g
Sweetened condensed milk	120 g
Vanilla extract (optional)	2 g

Important: This is a conservative starting batch for testing absorption. Do not force all the soak into the cake. The amount absorbed depends on sponge thickness, baking and bowl size.

1. Combine the three milks in a bowl and whisk gently until uniform; avoid incorporating lots of air.

2. Taste before use. Condensed milk supplies most of the sweetness, so do not add sugar automatically.

3. Keep chilled until assembly. Spoon onto the sponge gradually rather than flooding it.

4. Whipped Cream Topping

Ingredient	Quantity
Cold whipping cream, 35% fat or higher	300 g
Icing sugar	20–25 g
Vanilla extract	3 g

Keep the cream, bowl and whisk cold. Whip cream, icing sugar and vanilla on medium speed until medium-firm peaks form. The tip should hold shape but remain smooth. Stop before it becomes grainy or buttery. With a hand whisk, work in a chilled bowl and check frequently.

5. Assembly — Dessert Bowls

1. Portion the sponge: Use a serrated knife to cut the completely cooled sponge into pieces that fit the bowls. Use gentle sawing movements and wipe the knife between cuts.

2. Build the base: Place a sponge piece in each shallow ceramic bowl. Trim or add a second piece as needed for an even base.

3. Soak gradually: Spoon the chilled three-milk mixture over the sponge in two or three additions. Pause between additions. Stop when moist throughout but still holding its shape; do not force all the soak into each bowl.

4. Pipe the topping: Pipe a neat swirl of whipped cream directly over the soaked sponge, or spread gently with a spoon.

5. Garnish: Add a few fresh strawberry pieces, a blueberry or fruit of choice. Keep the garnish restrained.

6. Chill: Cover and refrigerate at 4°C or colder for at least 4 hours; overnight gives a more integrated texture. Add delicate fruit just before serving if it releases excess juice.

6. Troubleshooting & Foolproof Checks

Sponge sinks in the centre: It may be underbaked, the oven may run cool, or the leavening may be excessive. Bake until the centre is set and check oven temperature.

Rubbery or gluey crumb: The batter was overmixed. Once wet and dry meet, mix only until the flour disappears.

Dry sponge: It may be overbaked. Check from 22 minutes and remove when the centre springs back and no wet batter remains.

Mushy dessert: Too much soak was added too quickly, or the sponge was underbaked. Add soak gradually and allow absorption between additions.

Sponge breaks while cutting: It may still be warm or the knife is pressing rather than sawing. Cool fully, chill briefly and use a serrated knife.

Grainy cream: It has been overwhipped. Stop at medium-firm peaks. If only slightly overwhipped, gently fold in a small splash of cold unwhipped cream.

7. Food Safety & Storage

Keep the three-milk mixture and finished desserts refrigerated at **4°C or below**. Do not leave dairy desserts at room temperature for more than 2 hours (or 1 hour in very hot conditions above 32°C). For best quality, serve within 2–3 days, covered and refrigerated. Use clean utensils and fresh fruit.

8. Production Checklist

- ■ Oven preheated; pan lined before mixing
- ■ Dry ingredients evenly sifted
- ■ Vinegar added last; batter baked promptly
- ■ Sponge fully baked and cooled before cutting
- ■ Three milks combined and kept chilled
- ■ Soak added in stages; sponge remains intact
- ■ Cream whipped to medium-firm peaks
- ■ Desserts covered and chilled for at least 4 hours

Chef’s final note: For consistent results, record your oven’s actual bake time and the quantity of soak each bowl absorbs. The sponge should be moist and tender, never floating in liquid. This recipe is eggless; check packaged ingredients for allergen statements.